in the past one year or so as the Modi government gains the upper hand in the fight against the arch-enemy of the Indian State, shrinking the threat to a much smaller amoebic blob of red confined largely to the Bastar region, where the fiercest battles are still on.

In 2014, when the Modi government came to power, 126 districts in 10 states were classified as the most affected. In early 2025, this count is down to 12, the majority being in Bastar; the remaining in the neighbouring districts of Odisha, Jharkhand, Maharashtra and MP. A feat no doubt impressive enough for the home minister to tell INDIA TODAY in an interview at his residence in Delhi, "I firmly believe that by March 2026, we will ensure that India will be totally free of the Naxal threat." (*See accompanying interview.*)

From the air, though, the government's biggest game-changing measure looks no more than an innocuous two-acre farm in the thick of a Bastar jungle, marked by a straggle of asbestos-roofed sheds and stray chicken. As the chopper approaches the makeshift helipad at Camp Puvarti of the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF), the mini dust storm it raises in its wake has the ground staff scurrying for cover. Only when the dust settles do you begin to see the menacing watch-towers manned by gun-toting marksmen ringing the camp.

Puvarti, situated on the edge of the Naxal-infected Sukma district, is guarded by CRPF's 150th battalion, whose catchy moniker is 'One-Five Zero, Jungle Hero'. Indeed, they all are. Puvarti was once the redoubt of the dreaded Madvi Hidma, the Naxal commander said to be the mastermind of more than two dozen deadly attacks on security forces, including the one at the nearby Tadmetla village in 2010 in which 76 CRPF troopers were killed. Until a year back, it was impossible for anyone representing the State, uniformed or otherwise, to enter Puvarti without permission from the People's Liberation Guerrilla Army's (PLGA) Battalion No. 1, under whose 'jurisdiction' the area falls.



AN ALERT FORCE
CRPF personnel demonstrating drone technology; (right) carrying out aerial reconnaissance in Bijapur district; (bottom) keeping vigil at Puvarti camp

Repulsing four major attacks from the PLGA when the camp was set up a year ago, the 150 Battalion successfully drove the Naxal militia deeper into the jungles, establishing the CRPF's dominance in the area. The only warning Rakesh Shukla, the unflappable camp commandant, gives now with a smile is, "We have plenty of scorpions still around, and snakes, especially the krait, who treat our beds as theirs—so be sure to check your blanket before turning in."

Later that night, a patrol searches the surrounding jungle for suspicious activity but not before a minesweeper has vigorously scanned the path they are to take. The Naxals' biggest weapon is the Improvised Explosive Device (IED) or the mines they plant on roads that can maim a person or even kill them. It's pitch dark and the patrol walks in a single file with a hand on the shoulder of the person in front as the leader scans the jungle with night vision binoculars. Another patrol sets out in the morning, again in a single file, but on a fleet of motorcycles, the favoured mode of transport that helps avoid the mines.

A MULTI-PRONGED STRATEGY

Camps like Puvarti are designated Forward Operating Bases or FOBs and have become the lynchpin of the Modi government's multi-pronged strategy to rid India of the Naxal threat by next spring. Rakesh Agrawal, the affable IG, CRPF, Chhattisgarh sector, explains why the FOBs have become a game-changer.

"The Naxal ecosystem has been hit hard and is rapidly on its way out. The chances of revival are slim now"

— AMIT SHAH, *Union Home Minister, to* India Today, *Feb. 23*

